



FRIENDS AND FOES:
BACHCHAN WITH MODI (LEFT),
WITH ASHOK CHAVAN AT
THE INAUGURATION OF
THE MUMBAI SEA LINK



JUST AS BACHCHAN WAS MULAYAM'S ALL-ACCESS PASS TO MODERNITY, HE MAY BE MODI'S TICKET TO A MAKEOVER.

he once was and his son, though one of the busiest and best actors in Bollywood, is not its most successful. Even at the height of the Bollywood boom, the combined fees of the three stars was only one-third that of Akshay Kumar's. And the glue for any alliance of mutual gratification is success in the core competence.

Bollywood stars have realised the power of alliances, of battling power with power—those with long memories, says Pritish Nandy, cannot forget how Kishore Kumar suffered at the hands of Sanjay Gandhi during the Emergency, with his shows being cancelled, Income-Tax harassment, and his songs being banned on All India Radio and Doordarshan. If Bachchan had the triple As, Shah Rukh Khan had Mukesh Ambani and the younger Gandhis on his side. He was also the first to realise the power of cricketaiment by aligning with Lalit Modi, something everyone from Sanjay Dutt to Salman Khan, Saif Ali Khan to Kareena Kapoor, have understood too late. Seeing Roy buy Team Pune for \$370 million must have also made Bachchan wish for what might have been. Though Amar Singh and

Bachchan remain personally close—they were last seen together at a function at Symbiosis in Pune—there is clearly some unhappiness that has crept into that perfect union, given Jaya Bachchan's refusal to quit the party of her mentor till her Rajya Sabha term is over in July. Amar Singh in typical dramatic fashion bared his soul to the motley crowd that was present at the Kshatriya Mahakumbh rally in Delhi, reminding her that he was insulted by the very party she was still in.

Modi's Gujarat is to Bachchan now what Amar's Uttar Pradesh was then. Just as the Bachchan brand lent Mulayam Singh Yadav much needed glamour to cover up a pre-historic agenda that opposed English and computers, so Modi is hoping Bachchan's iconic status will give him a much-sought-after makeover. Especially as he is trying so hard to shed his tag of being Rioter-in-Chief. Bachchan has already insulated himself in Mumbai with Bal Thackeray's embarrassingly effusive endorsement. No matter how vicious

Raj Thackeray's threats, he cannot compete with his uncle's avowedly apolitical friend. As the business-entertainment-politics complex has shown, it doesn't hurt to have a buddy who has or will have some clout in Delhi. It helps in getting tax exemption, allows movies to be released without protest from the lunatic fringe, enables thugs to sometimes stage dharnas in your favour and in the case of some actors, keeps them out of jail. It's the reason stars allow themselves to be used for campaigning during elections and social causes in between. Actors have, as Mahesh Bhatt says, realised they are just the icing, not the cake. Political patronage ensures commercial insulation. It's something Bachchan first experimented with when he showed Thackeray Mani Ratnam's controversial *Bombay* before its release in 1995. Will he do the same with Mani Ratnam's big budget *Raavana* with its potentially explosive theme of Sita (Aishwarya Rai Bachchan) being attracted to Raavana (Abhishek Bachchan)? It will be worth knowing what Bachchan's new-found defenders, Modi and the BJP, think of that. ■